

evoke any anecdote at all on its own. Whereas a one-sentence pizza-eating *anecdote* is easily capable of coaxing explicit memories out of your unconscious storehouse, most if not all of the *words* making it up do no such thing. Look, for instance, at the various words in this very paragraph and ask yourself if any of them — for example, “ate”, “but”, “humble”, or “words” — summoned an entire anecdote to mind.

We would be lost if every single word (or stock phrase or idiomatic expression) in a long tale dredged its own anecdote up out of long-term memory. Were that to happen, we would be engulfed in a tidal wave of random stories and we would drown in the catastrophic mental confusion that would ensue. But luckily no such thing takes place, because only once in a blue moon does a mere word in a story (a “cameo actor”, so to speak) trigger the retrieval of an anecdote.

Danny and Dick, Canyon and Karnak: A Canonical Reminding

Reminding is a profound mystery, as the following case shows.

Doug and Carol arrive with their son Danny, fifteen months old, at the Grand Canyon’s North Rim. While his parents are captivated by the huge chasm, Danny is riveted by a few ants and a leaf on the sandy ground, fifty feet from the canyon’s edge. For a moment Doug is surprised, but then he realizes that such a young child is unable to appreciate entities of dimensions greater than ten or twenty feet, let alone miles (and the Grand Canyon is many miles wide). Although his infant son’s reaction now makes perfect sense, Doug cannot suppress a smile at the irony of the situation.

Fast-forward roughly fifteen years. Doug and his two children get off their cruise ship on the Nile in the city of Luxor. They are with their friends Kellie and Dick, and the whole group sets off on foot for the famed Temple of Karnak. While the other visitors are soon absorbed by the splendor of the great columns that surround them and by the erudition of their guide, Dick is irresistibly drawn to a few bottlecaps he spots lying in the dirt, and he leans down with joy to pick them up, thereby augmenting a modest collection that he’d started when they landed in Egypt just a few days earlier.

This act, reflecting Dick’s fascination with rusty knickknacks on the ground as opposed to the splendor of the ancient ruins soaring above, reminds Doug of something far back in his past: the time when his tiny son was engrossed by a handful of insects scuttling about on the ground rather than by the awesome sights surrounding him.

Below we present a more lyrical viewpoint on these two parallel stories, coming from our friend Kellie Gutman, who recounted them in the form of verse. The poem about her husband Dick was written originally to commemorate their cruise down the Nile, and a couple of years later, when we asked her, Kellie graciously indulged us by writing a twin poem about Danny at the Grand Canyon, adhering to precisely the same poetic constraints. For the French version of our book, we translated these two poems, once again obeying all the original poetic constraints, and in Chapter 6, where we discuss the role of analogy in translation, we will come back to these poems.

Arizona Ants

*When Doug and Carol and their son,
a toddling Danny, all of one,
left Indiana on a trip
out West, they knew they couldn't skip
the Grandest Canyon known, bar none.
They piled into their clipper ship*

*with no set plan, but just a notion
to shoot for the Pacific Ocean,
with detours here and there, thus reaping
the benefits of highways sweeping
across the landscape. Gentle motion
would lull their infant into sleeping,*

*while Mom and Dad drank in the views
of Colorado's Rockies, whose
steep craggy peaks filled them with awe.
They drove through reservations, saw
the Navajo, and got to choose
some turquoise stones without a flaw.*

*At last, the North Rim: strange striations
with shades evoking exclamations —
unless you're Danny... Then you treasure
the leaves and bugs! While grownups measure
the grandeur of vast rock formations,
you play with ants — a simpler pleasure.*

Karnak Caps

*The bottlecaps were all around
us, rusted remnants that once crowned
the Cokes and Fantas near the shop
that sold falafels, where we'd stop.
In Alexandria, the ground
was paved with flattened tops from pop.*

*We left for Cairo next, departing
the same day Dick announced, "I'm starting
an Egypt bottlecap collection!"
Each specimen, upon inspection,
was added to his pile for carting
back home. He had a wide selection:*

*in every bar, for every beer,
his pointing outstretched hand made clear
the cap was what he had in mind.
On dusty streets, he searched behind
the soda stands (a new frontier!),
and often came back with a find.*

*In Karnak's heat, our guide expounded
on gods and temples, while surrounded
by columns far too grand to measure.
We contemplated them with pleasure,
but as we gazed on high, dumbfounded,
Dick stooped to pluck a humbler treasure.*

As described here, Doug's reminding may not seem particularly striking, but you have been handed the two analogous scenarios on a silver platter. It would be quite simple, *ex post facto*, to display in a diagram the identical conceptual skeletons of the two situations, or to encode each separate story into a concise sequence of formal expressions exhibiting a perfect one-to-one correspondence. But such a diagram or chart would not do justice to what goes on in the human mind when such reminders take place out of the blue. Such a display would be reminiscent once again of Procrustes, who always obtains the result he desires (in this case, his heart is set on creating a flawless one-to-one matchup between two sequences of formal expressions) but only at a great sacrifice (a complete neglect of the complex mental processing that underlies the discovery of the analogy), which makes the whole exercise of little interest. An *ex post facto* diagram might be an elegant summary of the result of Doug's reminding, but it wouldn't cast the slightest light on how the reminding took place inside his head.

There is, after all, a deep scientific mystery here. Over fifteen years had elapsed since the Grand Canyon visit, and in all that time, Doug had only very rarely — a handful of times at most — thought about that fleeting moment of fascination, on his son's part, for the ants and the leaf. While they were on their Nile cruise, the furthest thing from Doug's mind was this memory. How, then, could such a distant, shadowy memory have been so rapidly and easily brought back to life in Doug's mind?

The Enigma of Encoding

As we pointed out at the start of Chapter 1, everyday situations are not handed to us in pre-wrapped packages — that is, with precise boundaries that surgically carve them away from the rest of the world. Rather, we filter our environment, dealing with only part of it, and in a biased manner. Each person somehow “decides” (that is, encodes) what a situation includes and doesn't include, and what its key ingredients are. This of course takes place on the fly and not in the least consciously: at every moment of our life, we are as busy as a beaver, encoding situations in memory along dimensions that will determine which future events will be able to remind us of these situations.

How was the small event at the Grand Canyon originally perceived by Doug and stored in his memory? The privileged candidates for the encoding were, first of all, the most local and visually salient aspects of the scene — thus, the huge canyon, the little boy sitting on the sand, the sandy soil, the ants, the leaf, and so forth. Next, on a more global level, the encoding might have included the reasons for the trip, the route that had been followed, the other national parks that had been visited, the car they were driving, the year, the season, the weather that afternoon, the ever-present car seat for the toddler, and various other details.

Other more abstract aspects of the situation were certainly encoded as well — namely, the relative sizes of the key entities in the story, and their wildly different levels of importance in the culture (the fame of the canyon as opposed to the insignificance of the ants and leaves). Last but not least, the feelings of surprise and irony were crucial aspects of this scene, and had to be included in the memory package as well. However, had Doug merely tagged this complex event with a very general label like “ironic” or “surprising”, that index on its own couldn't possibly have triggered the reminding, since untold thousands of other ironic and surprising events were stored in his memory, and none of those were brought to his mind by the Karnak bottlecap event.

Indeed, any event that Doug saw, no matter how ironic and surprising it might be, wouldn't stand a chance of re-evoking his memory of Danny at the Grand Canyon unless it shared other key features with that old story. However, local features alone wouldn't do the trick, either. The commonplace event of seeing somebody in a random place stoop over to pick up a small object on the ground would not suffice to get Doug to recall his son playing with ants at the Grand Canyon; if such a reminding took place, it would seem weird and senseless. Equally critical for the triggering of the old story is that the second event's encoding should explicitly include the contrast between an insignificant object and a grandiose setting, which gives rise to a sense of absurdity. We

thus see that the most abstract aspects of this situation mingled inseparably with some of its most specific aspects, and that the reminding was due to similarities at several levels at once. In short, the encoding of a situation, if it is to facilitate appropriate reminders in the future, must be both abstract and concrete. While the encoding has to retain some salient details, it must also include salient abstract characteristics.

A Trivial Side Show that is More Fascinating than the Main Event

To be sure, we don't want to suggest that an event has just *one* abstract structure. Speaking, *a posteriori*, of "the" abstract structure of an event gives the impression that there was and is only one correct way to perceive it and to have a memory of it get triggered, which is not the case; any of various distinct conceptual skeletons might get attached to a given situation, depending on the frame of mind one is in when it is encountered.

The wide variety of potential encodings of *Danny at the Grand Canyon* means that many extremely different situations, possibly encountered much later in life, could induce that old memory to bubble up from dormancy. Such situations would thereby become members of the category *Danny at the Grand Canyon*, or, to propose a more generic name for it, *trivial side show more fascinating than the main event*. Let's look at a few scenarios that might trigger such reminders:

A French family is taking a vacation in Italy's famed Cinque Terre region, on the Ligurian coast, where five small towns hug a rugged coastline. After finding a bed-and-breakfast place in the countryside, the parents are eager to set off and explore the towns, but the children, delighted by their discovery of a family of grasshoppers in the garden, refuse to budge.

A four-year-old girl has just received a lovely Christmas present, but she's paying no attention to it, concentrating instead on the sparkling wrapping paper.

In the cathedral-like main room of Cairo's Egyptian Museum, a boy is totally ignoring the tiny three-inch ivory statue of Kheops, which is the focus of all the guides and crowds; rather, his eye is caught by the cracked paint covering the vast room's high walls, in which he thinks he can make out the shapes of gigantic dragons and other fantastic monsters.

A young mother is more absorbed in the photos of her baby than in the baby itself.

A neurologist gives a talk to which she brings her ten-year-old niece, visiting for a few days. After the talk, the little girl says, "I liked your speech a lot, but I have just one question about it." The neurologist is delighted and even wonders if her niece is some kind of prodigy. Then the girl goes on, "When you thanked a bunch of people at the end and you mentioned someone named Janet, were you talking about my mom?"

A graphic artist is reading a famous novel but is paying less attention to the plot than to the typesetting and page layout.